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There is more than one striking feature in BJP's sweeping win in the Karnataka Assembly elections. Until this victory, the party was always seen as a north Indian phenomenon. It could not quite make inroads south of the Vindhyas where, it is said, India is another country. Born in the Hindi heartland, the party's core constituency and its national appeal, was always limited. But Karnataka promises to change all that.

In all probability, had the Congress won Karnataka, India would have been going to the polls sooner rather than later. But it has now been defeated in its last 12 assembly elections since 2005, and the aftershocks from those collective failures will be significantly felt in the ruling UPA coalition. With the general election less than a year away, there is little doubt that the shape of the coalition is going to change with the Congress's political allies now even more susceptible to crossing over. Already running a lame-duck Government that drags its feet over key political decisions, it seems likely the UPA will now grind to a complete halt and indulge in handing out more election sops for the rest of its term. This could have serious repercussions on the economy.

The national ramifications from Karnataka, therefore, are enormous. Gaining a foothold in the south has been a very big step for BJP which now has back to back victories in assembly elections alone or with allies in Bihar, Himachal Pradesh, Punjab, Uttarakhand, Gujarat and Karnataka. This is an impressive record in spite of the squabbling leadership at the national level. The ascent of B.S. Yeddyurappa has given them another strong leader at the state level who can rally support for the party across the region. The new emerging trend is that increasingly elections are being won by regional leaders rather than distant national figures.

This is exactly the crisis in the Congress. It ran a high-profile campaign in Karnataka but it is now clear that its trump card, Sonia Gandhi, cannot be guaranteed to pull in the votes anymore. The party has not groomed or supported a network of reliable, second-tier of regional leaders and its successive failures in the states continue to be proof of such shortcomings.

For our cover story this week, Editor Prabhu Chawla analyses the national implications of the Karnataka verdict while our political bureau reports on the fall of the Gowdas and the rise of the new regional satrap, Yeddyurappa.

At the moment BJP looks all set to work its way back to power at the Centre. It controls the major states headed by strong figures and appears to have learnt some lessons from its disastrous "India Shining" campaign of 2004. The challenge now will be to translate the regional vote into a national mandate. As for the Congress and UPA, there is an increased pressure to come up with a winning strategy for the general elections in the face of mounting defeats.

Aroon Purie
(Aroon Purie)